

Homelessness in Albuquerque and What Can Be Done About It.



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ABSTRACT

Homelessness in Albuquerque is complex and influenced by a combination of economic, social, and geographic characteristics of the region. This report investigates the role that public resources, climate, and urban design play in homelessness, particularly as it intersects with substance abuse, mental illness, and rising costs of housing. Resources from the University of New Mexico's online library, academic journals, books, and databases were used to better understand the factors contributing to and patterns of housing instability in Albuquerque.

The research revealed that a lack of affordable housing, limited access to long-term mental health treatment, and a rising number of people with addiction are all pushing people onto the streets. But there may also be a role that the city's Southwestern location and generally mild weather play in attracting homeless people to Albuquerque — especially from states farther north, like Colorado.

Comparisons with other cities across the country have found that integrated models of services and Housing First approaches have achieved promising results in reducing the number of people who experience long terms of homelessness. This report compares homelessness in one U.S. city to findings in other metropolitan areas. It then provides recommendations for expanding supportive housing programs, increasing resources for mental health and addiction services, and improving coordination and data collection among a variety of agencies and government offices.

Homelessness in Albuquerque must be addressed using an evidence-based approach that tackles the structural and individual complex problems that drive homelessness. The following recommendations for addressing homelessness in Albuquerque offer tangible and effective solutions for government entities, organizations, and stakeholders working to reduce homelessness in our community.

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Introduction Section

Homelessness has been a prolonged problem in many places. One of these places is the city of Albuquerque, New Mexico, USA, which has been trying to improve for a while now. From rehabilitation programs to worker programs like “There is a Better Way,” the city has been trying to help the homeless population reduce and provide people with the support they need to get off the streets and move into a more comfortable way of living.

Despite this, in recent years, the number of homeless people has doubled compared to previous years. This is due to many reasons that plague the community of Albuquerque, NM, such as a gap in housing affordability and employment in the city that has brought many people into poverty. From all different backgrounds and reasons, people have been and stayed homeless due to reasons that might be hard for them to control, and with little to no support, they are reduced to wandering the streets.

Homelessness, although it may seem simple to solve at first, is actually very complex. There are multiple factors to be considered to mental health, lack of resources, and addiction. There have been programs in the past, not just in Albuquerque but in many other cities across the U.S., to reduce homelessness. This report will examine the factors contributing to the growing number of people experiencing homelessness and what has been done and can continue to be done to help. As well as looking at what has not worked in the past to prevent further mistakes and have the best possible chance of success.

Methodology

In this report, we researched and discussed the climate of challenges driving homelessness in the city of Albuquerque. We then researched previous work on the venture of reducing homelessness in Albuquerque and abroad.

The first major step in our research process was determining the breadth and kinds of sources that we wanted to include in our research. This meant creating a topic map of homelessness and postulating what sources would have valuable information. We discussed the credibility of the various sources, and the lucrativeness of those sources, until we agreed on just 5. 3 of our 5 sources we found from the University of New Mexico electronic library. This is important because UNM main campus is situated on the north side of Central Ave, a major hotspot for homelessness and crime in Albuquerque.

The second major step of our research process was reading our sources. We had to do this in such a way that enough reading could get done within the time constraints we had, and so that we would be prepared for the third major step. We were looking for solutions discussed and implemented by other cities and states such as Sacramento, California, San Francisco, California, Rhode Island, Eugene, Oregon, and the original city in question, Albuquerque, New Mexico. We were also looking for reasons why homelessness is so hard, and how chronic homelessness persists.

Once we read all the material, we then regrouped and shared what we read, in the same effort to brainstorm ways of reducing homelessness in Albuquerque. When the different sources said similar things, that also supported the reliability of the information we were using. For example, multiple sources made it clear that substantial portions of the homeless population are struggling with substance abuse or mental disorders and need additional services to help them.

One limitation of our recommendations is given the case of a homeless person who doesn't want to work, and who doesn't change their mind when given health and self-esteem support. The systems by which we take care of each other may be abused. Not necessarily by 'lazy' homeless people but by stronger and more pervasive addictive substances. Our recommendations make participation in rehabilitation optional rather than a requirement.

Result summary

Throughout our research, we learned about the many factors that contribute to homelessness and possible ways to address it. In this section, we will go through 3 factors, what we learned from them, and how we can apply them to our recommendations.

Easy pathways to programs:

In our research, we learned that many homeless people don't get help because they don't know it exists in the first place or where to go for help. This is where programs like "There is a Better Way," created by the city of Albuquerque, come into play. Here, homeless people were able to get employment help after seeing flyers with a phone number to call, resulting in about 800 people exiting homelessness after some time in the program.

This shows how providing and sharing the right knowledge can help people who are homeless find the help they need and move into a better situation, rather than being stuck in one they don't know how to get out of.

Discrimination:

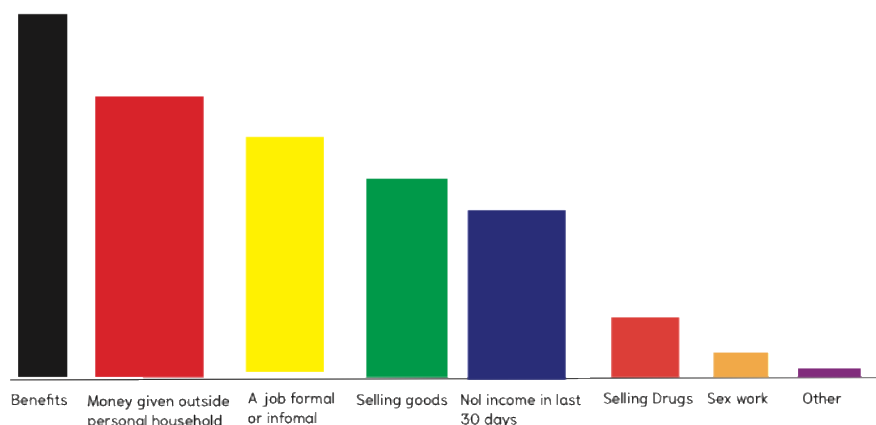
In one of our sources, we kept noticing that a barrier to helping the homeless is the discrimination they face from others. They are often looked down on and aren't taken seriously. This included not wanting to hire someone who is homeless just because they don't want to. This causes a problem because if employers are refusing to hire homeless people and there is no law stopping them from doing so, it imposes a challenge for people to be able to get money to then be able to get out of their situation if they are just kept being rejected. For this reason, there needs to be laws for employers stating that, under some circumstances, they are not allowed to discriminate against the homeless.

Housing and Financial help:

Most of our sources concentrated heavily on housing affordability and financial help. It is the reason most are homeless due to the lack of affordability of housing and supplies. They talked about how we can help people afford not just temporary housing but permanent housing.

This is important because studies show that while temporary housing is a good step psychologically, it isn't ideal, and we should focus on providing permanent housing. Financial programs are extremely helpful, but should be thought through as they can often be abused.

Likely Source of Income



Result Discussion

Homelessness in Albuquerque is the result of a variety of factors, both structural and individual. The most prominent reason for homelessness in the city is the cost of housing for very low-income individuals and families. Due to a general lack of low-income housing options in Albuquerque, many individuals and families living near poverty may experience the inability to afford and maintain safe and adequate housing, and as a result, become homeless. New Mexico is also facing a severe lack of affordable housing, the New Mexico Mortgage Finance Authority reports.

Further issues include the presence of mental health and substance use disorders. People experiencing homelessness have been found to have difficulty with decision-making and have difficulty accessing resources to end their homelessness. (Duncan, A. R., Posen, S. G., McLean, L. F. R., & Gervais, A. E. (2022)).

Programs are often minimally delivered, in that they are not packaged as part of an integrated system of effective and supportive programs and services. Instead, individuals and families experience a complex, fragmented, and often confusing array of different agencies and services.

Long-term solutions like permanent supportive housing are more effective than short-term fixes. Research has shown that housing provides dignity and is key to long-term success for people experiencing homelessness. C. Murphy tackled the issue in 2016. How does one get back on one's feet if one has no place to stand? Housing first.

Recommendations

Expand Coordinated Access to Services:

People are often deterred from advocacy by not knowing how to access and navigate systems to advocate for an issue that affects them. Providing a "one-stop shop" for access to various tools and resources could enhance opportunities for advocacy. Planning is crucial when it comes to supporting families and children in need, according to research published in 2022 by A. R. Duncan and colleagues. Currently, most organizations that aim to support vulnerable families are working in isolation. However, by finding ways to better coordinate their efforts, these services could become more effective.

Provide Landlords with Incentives to Rent Affordably:

Affordable housing is often provided through the medium of privately-owned housing, where landlords participate through incentives such as tax credits or protection from loss. This paper outlines an economic model which examines the likely impact of offering such incentives to encourage landlords to build affordable housing. In particular, the model is contrasted with previously proposed schemes to highlight potential advantages. This paper considers the potential for partnership between cities and housing providers to facilitate access to decent and affordable housing for all sections of the community. To realize this potential, first, the current limitations to participation by both cities and housing providers need to be identified and discussed.



Prioritize Permanent Supportive Housing Programs:

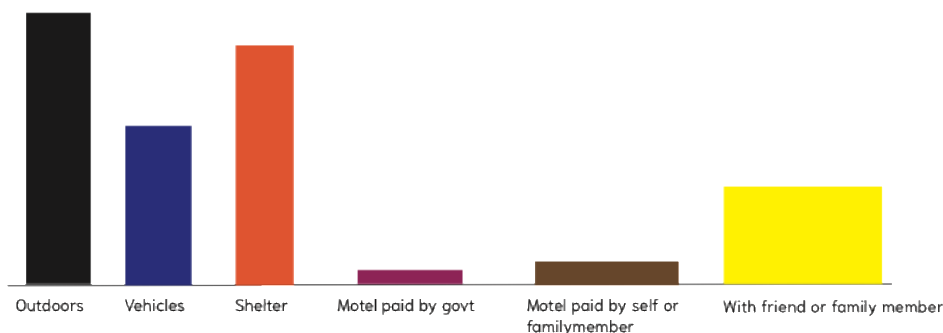
This report looks at the concept of Permanent Supportive Housing or PSH, which is a

permanents residence for extremely low-income individuals with disabilities who also receive supportive services such as mental health care and job training. C. Murphy, Housing First: How SDI Can Help Make Long-Term Success Possible, (2016) New Mexico Mortgage Finance Authority: Reducing Chronic Homelessness. Create a Local “Bill of Rights” for Homeless Individuals & Families and Present at National Conference on Ending Homelessness! Many social biases can prevent people and families from obtaining housing, employment and access to other critical services they need to survive with dignity. A Homeless Bill of Rights would guarantee many basic rights to all individuals and families who are homeless. Prevention and access to services are critical components to addressing overdose and addiction; the City of Albuquerque works to create and implement policies and programs that remove barriers to services and create equitable environments for all community members.

Provide Flexible Financial Assistance Programs:

Homelessness is typically a relatively short-term state resulting from transient periods of poverty. By assisting people who are experiencing homelessness with flexible funding for basic expenses related to stable and safe housing, YFS helps prevent and quickly address homelessness. Early intervention in the lives of families in need to prevent and treat homelessness, along with strategies to help stable low-income families, are critical components of a balanced housing policy. New Mexico Mortgage Finance Authority explains these strategies.

Places Homeless are likely to sleep at



Conclusion

Homelessness in Albuquerque is a detrimental problem that is caused by a combination of several factors, the primary causes being lack of funds, the paucity of homeless housing options, and the inadequate collaboration and communication among service providers. For some, mental health and substance abuse may be factors, but many more basic reasons are at play, such as poverty and a lack of affordable housing. In addressing homelessness, it is essential to recognize the complexities of the problem and the interconnected nature of its various factors.

Addressing these factors requires a comprehensive effort to address the root causes of homelessness. Findings from the survey suggest that tackling homelessness in the short term is not enough, and that work is needed in the longer term. This could involve increasing the supply of affordable housing, improving the linkage between street and mainstream services, as well as supporting people in financial need and those with mental health problems.

There is nothing quite as important to achieving long-term goals as having a safe and reliable place to call home. A home base anchors a person and brings stability and dignity into their life – precisely what someone who is trying to get their life together needs.

“Stable housing provides a sense of home and dignity to a person who may be trying to get their life back together,” said C. Murphy, executive director of Pathways Inc. in 2016. Now it’s time to put these ideas into action here in Albuquerque. However, in order to make progress on this complex issue, the city will need to continue to work with many homeless interest groups and the community as a whole.

Glossary of Terms

Affordable Housing

Housing that costs no more than 30% of a household's income, allowing individuals and families to afford other necessities such as food, transportation, and healthcare.

Chronic Homelessness

A condition in which an individual experiences homelessness for a long period of time or repeatedly, often while also facing a disability such as mental illness or substance use disorder.

Coordinated Access System

A structured system that connects individuals experiencing homelessness to housing and services through a single, organized entry point.

Discrimination (Housing/Employment)

Unfair treatment of individuals based on their housing status, which can limit access to jobs, housing, and essential services.

Housing First

An approach to addressing homelessness that prioritizes providing permanent housing before requiring participation in treatment programs or other conditions.

Mental Health Disorders

Conditions that affect a person's thinking, mood, or behavior, which can impact their ability to maintain stable housing.

Permanent Supportive Housing (PSH)

Long-term housing that includes supportive services such as mental health care, substance use treatment, and job assistance for individuals with high needs.

Substance Use Disorder

A medical condition characterized by the inability to control the use of substances such as drugs or alcohol, often impacting daily functioning and stability.

Transitional Housing

Temporary housing is designed to help individuals move from homelessness to permanent housing, typically with time limits and support services.

Very Low-Income Individuals

People or families whose income is significantly below the median income in their area, making it difficult to afford basic living expenses, including housing.

Housing Instability

A condition in which individuals are at risk of losing housing due to financial hardship, unsafe living conditions, or frequent moves.

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